The Southeast Cruiser's Port Guide

Drive Times, Parking, Hotels & Cruise Lines
for Every Major Port Within Reach of
Georgia · Tennessee · Alabama · Florida

Presented by Crestwell Travel Services

ASTA Member · CLIA Certified · Chattanooga, TN

A Quick Note From Tim

If you live in the Southeast, you have access to more cruise ports than almost anyone else in the country. Six major ports within a single day's drive. Direct flights to a seventh. But here's what nobody tells you:

Choosing the right port can swing the cost of the exact same cruise by $400–$1,200. Same cabin, same itinerary, same dates — just a different departure city.

This guide is the shortcut. Twelve pages, no fluff, no upsell. After you read it, you'll know exactly which port to sail from for your next vacation — and whether to drive or fly.

If you want a personal recommendation after reading, reach out. Our planning is completely free.

Happy cruising,

Tim Crestwell

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How to Use This Guide

Every port profile includes six things: drive times from major Southeast cities, which cruise lines sail from that port, which itineraries are available, parking costs, a recommended pre-cruise hotel, and Tim's honest take — including when to skip a port. Ports are ordered from nearest to the Southeast corridor outward.

Port 1: Port of Mobile

Alabama

201 S Water St, Mobile, AL 36602

DRIVE TIMES

Birmingham	4.5 hours
Huntsville	4 hours
Atlanta	5.5 hours
Nashville	5.5 hours
Chattanooga	5.5 hours
Knoxville	7 hours
Memphis	7.5 hours
Savannah	8 hours

CRUISE LINES

Carnival Cruise Line — Carnival Spirit sails year-round.

ITINERARIES

4- to 7-night Western Caribbean sailings. Typical ports: Cozumel, Costa Maya, Progreso, Mahogany Bay (Roatán).

PARKING

~$18/night at the port's official garage. Pre-pay online for a small discount.

RECOMMENDED PRE-CRUISE HOTEL

Renaissance Mobile Riverview Plaza — walking distance to the terminal, great on-site restaurant, and reasonable park-and-cruise packages that include a week of parking with your room night.

Tim's Take

Mobile is the best-kept secret on this list. Often $200–$500 cheaper per cabin than the same Carnival itinerary out of New Orleans or Tampa, drive-accessible for almost every Southeast city, and the port itself is small and painless. If you're in Alabama, Tennessee, or Georgia and haven't considered Mobile, you're leaving money on the table.

Downside: only one ship, so itinerary variety is limited. Book early for peak seasons.

Port 2: New Orleans

Louisiana

Julia Street & Erato Street Cruise Terminals (foot of the CBD)

DRIVE TIMES

Birmingham	6 hours
Memphis	6 hours
Huntsville	6 hours
Atlanta	7 hours
Nashville	8 hours
Chattanooga	8.5 hours
Savannah	9 hours

CRUISE LINES

Norwegian, Carnival, Royal Caribbean — rotating ships throughout the year.

ITINERARIES

5- to 7-night Western Caribbean. Typical ports: Cozumel, Costa Maya, Roatán, Harvest Caye (Belize).

PARKING

~$25/night at the official port garages. Off-site private lots run $12–$18/night with shuttle service.

RECOMMENDED PRE-CRUISE HOTEL

Hilton New Orleans Riverside — directly connected to the Julia Street terminal, full French Quarter access, and arguably the most convenient pre-cruise stay in any US port.

Tim's Take

New Orleans is the play if you want a cruise *plus* a destination-city experience without flying. Spend two nights on Bourbon Street, board Sunday, and you've stacked two vacations into one. Pricing is usually a tick higher than Mobile but you get bigger ships and more itinerary variety.

Downside: traffic in and out of downtown NOLA can be rough on sail day. Build in a buffer or stay downtown the night before.

Port 3: Jacksonville

Florida

JAXPORT Cruise Terminal, 9810 August Dr, Jacksonville, FL 32226

DRIVE TIMES

Savannah	2 hours
Atlanta	5.5 hours
Chattanooga	7 hours
Birmingham	8 hours
Huntsville	8 hours
Nashville	9.5 hours

CRUISE LINES

Carnival Cruise Line — Carnival Elation (check current deployment; ships rotate).

ITINERARIES

4- to 5-night Bahamas sailings. Typical ports: Nassau, Princess Cays, Half Moon Cay.

PARKING

~$17/night. Often included in park-and-cruise hotel packages.

RECOMMENDED PRE-CRUISE HOTEL

Four Points by Sheraton Jacksonville Baymeadows or similar park-and-cruise hotels near the airport — most offer free port shuttle and 5 days of free parking bundled with your room night, often cheaper than parking at the port alone.

Tim's Take

Jacksonville is the ultimate "quick getaway" cruise port for the Southeast. Short itineraries, low prices, minimal logistics. If you're in Savannah or South Georgia, it's a no-brainer. For Atlanta and further north, it's a comfortable day drive for a family willing to leave early Friday morning.

Downside: limited ship selection and only Bahamas itineraries. Not your port for a 10-night Caribbean.

Port 4: Port Canaveral

Florida

Cruise Terminals 1, 3, 5, 8, 10 (different terminals for different cruise lines)

DRIVE TIMES

Savannah	4.5 hours
Atlanta	7 hours
Chattanooga	9 hours
Birmingham	9.5 hours
Knoxville	9.5 hours
Nashville	fly
Memphis	fly

CRUISE LINES

Disney Cruise Line, Carnival, Royal Caribbean, Norwegian, MSC — one of the busiest ports in the country with a huge range of ships.

ITINERARIES

3- to 7-night Bahamas and Caribbean. Home of Disney's Castaway Cay and Lookout Cay; Royal Caribbean's Perfect Day at CocoCay.

PARKING

~$17–$20/night at the port. Off-site lots offer shuttle service at similar rates.

RECOMMENDED PRE-CRUISE HOTEL

Residence Inn Cape Canaveral Cocoa Beach for families (suites, free breakfast, port shuttle) or **Hilton Cocoa Beach Oceanfront** if you want beach time before the cruise.

> **Tim's Take**
>
> If you have kids, Port Canaveral is probably your port. Disney Cruise Line's fleet is here, Royal Caribbean's CocoCay itineraries launch from here, and the 3- and 4-night options make it the easiest "add a cruise to our Orlando trip" port in the country.
>
> **Downside:** it's popular, which means peak-season pricing and more crowded terminals.

Port 5: Tampa

Florida

Port Tampa Bay, 815 Channelside Dr, Tampa, FL 33602

DRIVE TIMES

Atlanta	7 hours
Savannah	7 hours
Chattanooga	9 hours
Knoxville	9.5 hours
Birmingham	10 hours
Nashville	11 hours (fly)

CRUISE LINES

Carnival, Royal Caribbean, Norwegian, Holland America (seasonal).

ITINERARIES

4- to 7-night Western Caribbean. Typical ports: Cozumel, Grand Cayman, Costa Maya.

PARKING

~$15/night at the port — one of the cheaper options in Florida.

RECOMMENDED PRE-CRUISE HOTEL

Embassy Suites by Hilton Tampa Downtown Convention Center — walking distance to the terminal, free breakfast, consistently strong reviews.

Tim's Take

Tampa is one of the most underrated ports on this list. Less crowded than Miami, easier to get in and out of than Fort Lauderdale, and the drive down I-75 from Atlanta is one of the more relaxed Florida drives. Great option if you want Western Caribbean without the Gulf Coast Mobile/NOLA experience.

Downside: ship clearance under the Sunshine Skyway Bridge limits which ships can sail from Tampa, so you won't see the newest mega-ships here.

Port 6: Port Everglades

Fort Lauderdale, Florida

1850 Eller Dr, Fort Lauderdale, FL 33316

DRIVE TIMES

Savannah	9 hours
Atlanta	10 hours
Everyone else	fly

CRUISE LINES

Princess, Holland America, Celebrity, Royal Caribbean, Norwegian, Cunard, Silversea. Home of Allure of the Seas.

ITINERARIES

Everything from 3-night Bahamas to 14-night Caribbean and transatlantic repositioning cruises. Widest selection of longer itineraries of any Southeast-accessible port.

PARKING

~$22/night at the port. Off-site lots run $10–$15/night with shuttles.

RECOMMENDED PRE-CRUISE HOTEL

Embassy Suites by Hilton Fort Lauderdale 17th Street — 10 minutes from the port, free shuttle, suites for families.

> **Tim's Take**
>
> Fort Lauderdale is Miami's quieter, more civilized sibling. Better if you want longer itineraries (10, 11, 14 nights) or premium lines like Celebrity and Princess. For Southeast travelers, it's a fly-in port — the 9+ hour drive doesn't make sense unless you're stacking a South Florida vacation onto the cruise.
>
> **Downside:** flights into FLL from the Southeast are often more expensive than Miami. Always price both.

Port 7: Port of Miami

Florida

PortMiami, 1015 N America Way, Miami, FL 33132

DRIVE TIMES

Everyone	Fly — direct from ATL, BNA, BHM, MEM, TYS, and SAV

CRUISE LINES

Royal Caribbean, Carnival, MSC, Virgin Voyages, Celebrity, Norwegian, Disney, Oceania, Regent, Seabourn — more cruise lines than any other US port.

ITINERARIES

Everything. 3-night weekenders to 14-night Southern Caribbean. Home of Royal Caribbean's Icon of the Seas and the world's largest cruise ships.

PARKING

~$26/night at the port. Off-site options (MIA Cruise Parking, Park 'N Go) run $12–$18/night with shuttles.

RECOMMENDED PRE-CRUISE HOTEL

InterContinental Miami — downtown, walkable to the port, true city experience. Or **Hyatt Centric Las Olas Fort Lauderdale** if you want a quieter pre-cruise night and can shuttle over in the morning.

Tim's Take

Miami is where you go for the newest ships. If you want Icon of the Seas, Utopia of the Seas, the new Virgin Voyages ships, or any Royal Caribbean mega-ship — it's here. Always fly in, always stay one night pre-cruise (flight delays are a real risk), and book transfers in advance.

Downside: peak-season traffic from MIA to the port can easily add 45 minutes. Build in a real buffer.

Flying vs. Driving: The Real Math

Here's the honest framework:

DRIVE IF…

• The port is under 6 hours from your house

• You're a family of 4 or more (baggage fees add up fast)

• You want flexibility on arrival time

• You're bringing lots of luggage or special gear

FLY IF…

• The port is 8+ hours away

• You can get a direct flight for under $300/person round-trip

• You're a couple or small group

• Your departure day is midweek (flights are cheaper)

The middle zone (6–8 hours) is a real toss-up. Once you add gas ($100–$150 round-trip), a pre-cruise hotel night ($150–$250), and port parking for a week ($150), driving often costs nearly as much as flying — without the speed. When we quote a trip, we price both options and show you the real numbers. No guesswork.

The Five Biggest Mistakes Southeast Cruisers Make

1. Booking the cruise line's "posted" price.

Cruise line websites almost never show you the best rate. Travel advisors have access to promotions, group amenity points, and onboard credit stacks that the public never sees. This alone can save you $200–$800 per cabin.

2. Arriving the morning of the cruise.

One delayed flight, one traffic jam on I-75, and your cruise sails without you. The cruise line doesn't refund you, and travel insurance coverage varies. **Always arrive the day before** for any cruise requiring a flight.

3. Picking the wrong cabin category.

The difference between an oceanview and a balcony is often only $200–$400 per person — and completely changes the experience. On the flip side, an interior cabin on a 3-night Bahamas cruise (where you'll be on deck the whole time anyway) is a smart save.

4. Booking the first itinerary that catches your eye.

The same cruise line, same ship, same ports — sailing two weeks earlier or later — can be $500+ cheaper. Flexibility on dates is the single biggest lever for a better price.

5. Skipping travel insurance.

Especially for Caribbean cruises during hurricane season. "Cancel for any reason" policies exist and are worth it for high-value trips. We help every client evaluate whether it makes sense for their specific trip.

Your Next Step

You now know more about Southeast cruise ports than 95% of people booking them. But the real value isn't in knowing which port is closest — it's in knowing which combination of port + cruise line + itinerary + cabin + timing works for **your** specific trip.

That's where we come in.

Send us a message with:

• Where you're thinking of going

• Roughly when you'd like to travel

• How many people in your party

• A rough budget (optional but helpful)

We'll send you three hand-picked options within 24 hours. No planning fees, ever, and no pressure.

Ready to plan your next cruise?

Request your free quote: crestwellgetaways.com/request-quote

Call: 888.508.6893

Email: info@crestwellgetaways.com

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